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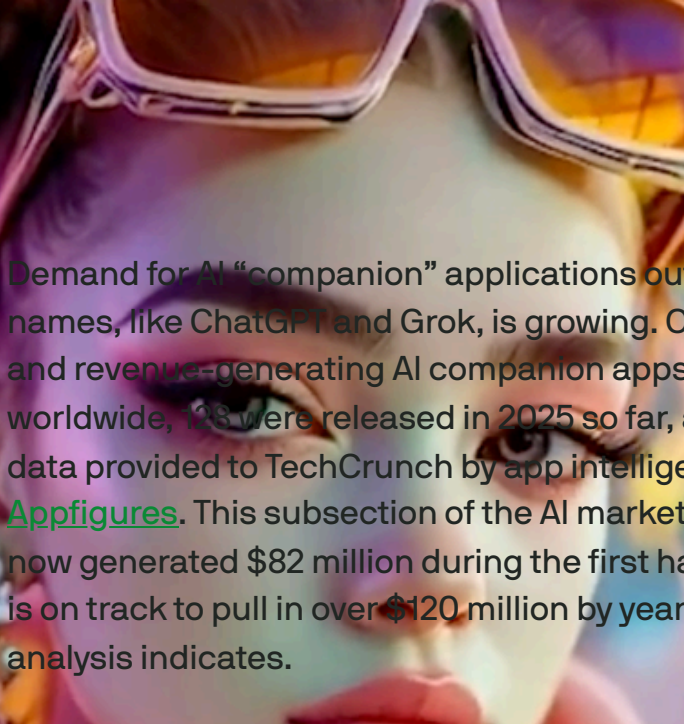
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APPS



AI companion apps on track to pull in \$120M in 2025



Demand for AI “companion” applications outside of bigger names, like ChatGPT and Grok, is growing. Of the 337 active and revenue-generating AI companion apps available worldwide, 128 were released in 2025 so far, according to new data provided to TechCrunch by app intelligence firm [Appfigures](#). This subsection of the AI market on mobile has now generated \$82 million during the first half of the year and is on track to pull in over \$120 million by year-end, the firm’s analysis indicates.

AI Companion Apps Released by Year

Number of Apps Still Active • Worldwide • iOS and Google Play



¹ Partial year through July 2025

Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

Unlike general-purpose chatbots, AI companion apps anthropomorphize AI interactions by allowing users to converse with custom characters, including friends, lovers, girlfriends or boyfriends, fantasy characters, and more. Appfigures defined the market segment in the same way, describing companion apps as those in which the user can interact with either premade or user-generated synthetic characters meant to embody an actual personality.

Popular apps in this space include Replika, Character.AI, PolyBuzz, Chai, and others.

As of July 2025, AI companion apps across the Apple App Store and Google Play have been downloaded 220 million times globally. During the first half of 2025, downloads were up 88% year-over-year, reaching 60 million.



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AI Companion Apps Released in First Half of Each Year

Number of Apps Still Active • Worldwide • iOS and Google Play



Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

Appfigures crunched the numbers and found that, as of July 2025, AI companion apps have driven \$221 million in consumer spending worldwide. So far this year, these apps have generated 64% more revenue than during the same period in 2024.

The top 10% of all AI companion apps generate 89% of the revenue in the category, the data shows. In addition, around 10% (or 33) of the apps have exceeded \$1 million in lifetime consumer spending.

AI Companion Revenue Share for Top 10% of Apps

Worldwide • iOS and Google Play



Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

Revenue per download is also up \$0.66, from \$0.52 in 2024 to \$1.18 for the category so far in 2025.

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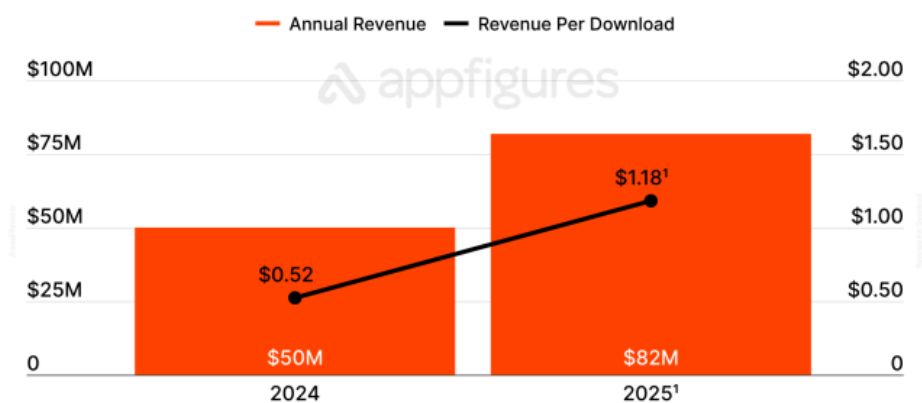
While dedicated AI companion apps are fairly popular, bigger companies like xAI are also moving into the market. In July, [xAI's Grok launched AI companions](#), including an anime girl and [guy](#), as well as a snarky 3D fox.

Meanwhile, ChatGPT's recent upgrade to [GPT-5](#) brought to light the fact that many of its users felt a kinship with the older model, as they [mourned](#) the loss of their AI companion, whom they had [come to depend upon](#).

To address these and other concerns about GPT-5's performance, [OpenAI CEO Sam Altman brought back the 4o model](#) for the time being.

AI Companion App Spending By Year and Per Download

Estimated Consumer Spending • Worldwide • iOS and Google Play



¹ Partial year through July 2025

Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

Google last year tapped into the market, too, when it [hired away Character.ai's founder, Noam Shazeer](#). The Character.ai app lives on and still has [tens of millions](#) of monthly active users.

According to Appfigures' data, the most popular AI companion apps are those used by people looking for an AI girlfriend. Of the active apps on the market today, 17% have an app name that includes the word "girlfriend," compared with 4% that say

“boyfriend” or “fantasy.” Terms like anime, soulmate, and lover, among others, are less frequently mentioned.

Name Includes	Count	% of Total
Girlfriend	56	17%
Fantasy	14	4%
Boyfriend	13	4%
Anime	11	3%
Soul	10	3%
Soulmate	7	2%
Lover	6	2%
Waifu	3	1%

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

The firm notes there were likely a number of other AI companion apps that launched on the app stores since 2022, but were later removed after failing to gain traction in terms of revenue or downloads. Those weren’t factored into its analysis, however.

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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at...

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APPS



X's declining Android app installs are hurting subscription revenue

Sarah Perez — 1:49 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

Elon Musk's X is struggling on Android devices in terms of new installs, even while App Store downloads grow, according to new data from app intelligence provider Appfigures. In July 2025, X downloads on Google Play saw a significant decline, as new installs dropped by 44% year-over-year worldwide, even as iOS downloads grew by 15%.

This steep drop in installs is pulling down X's overall average, leading to a 26% decrease in total mobile downloads year-over-year as of July. That's still slightly better than the month prior, when total downloads had fallen by 35%, thanks to another sharp drop in Android downloads, which were then down by nearly half (49%) year-over-year.

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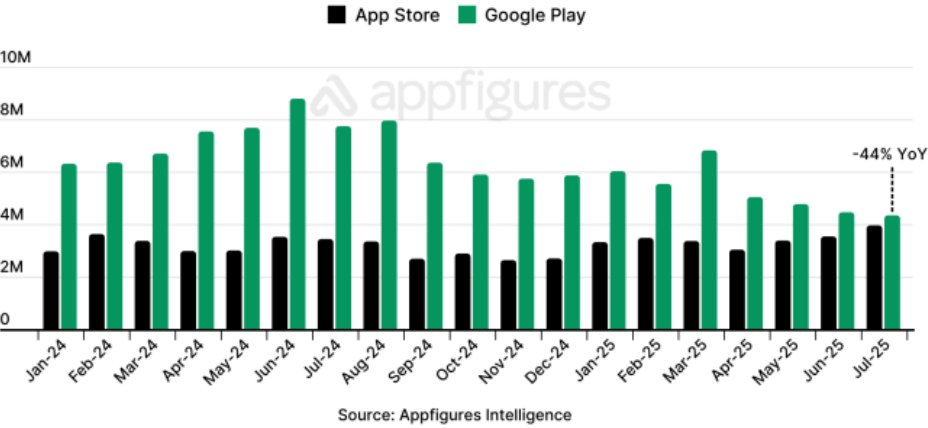


IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

The firm didn’t speculate on what’s causing the decline on Android devices beyond suggesting that the X app on Android is known to be a sore spot for the company. Recently hired [X head of product Nikita Bier](#), known for growth hacking teen social apps like [Gas](#) and [TBH](#) (then [selling them](#)), has hinted that X is looking to address issues on Android, where its app is [notoriously buggy](#) and [often crashes](#).

In a post on the platform, Bier [announced](#) that X was hiring for its “Android Dream Team” to work on rebuilding the X Android app. He also recently posted that X’s iOS app [had just seen a record week in terms of installs](#), perhaps hoping to draw attention away from the large Android slump.

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New X Downloads on Mobile by Month with Year-Over-Year Growth

Estimated Downloads • Worldwide • App Store and Google Play

Month	App Store	YoY	Google Play	YoY	Unified	YoY
Jan-24	2,963,000	-	6,303,000	-	9,266,000	-
Feb-24	3,623,000	-	6,352,000	-	9,975,000	-
Mar-24	3,363,000	-	6,689,000	-	10,052,000	-
Apr-24	2,971,000	-	7,536,000	-	10,507,000	-
May-24	2,993,000	-	7,676,000	-	10,669,000	-
Jun-24	3,514,000	-	8,787,000	-	12,301,000	-
Jul-24	3,429,000	-	7,742,000	-	11,171,000	-
Aug-24	3,338,000	-	7,953,000	-	11,291,000	-
Sep-24	2,679,000	-	6,347,000	-	9,026,000	-
Oct-24	2,876,000	-	5,895,000	-	8,771,000	-
Nov-24	2,629,000	-	5,735,000	-	8,364,000	-
Dec-24	2,691,000	-	5,861,000	-	8,552,000	-
Jan-25	3,312,000	12%	6,019,000	-5%	9,331,000	1%
Feb-25	3,475,000	-4%	5,535,000	-13%	9,010,000	-10%
Mar-25	3,359,000	0%	6,814,000	2%	10,173,000	1%
Apr-25	3,029,000	2%	5,032,000	-33%	8,061,000	-23%
May-25	3,370,000	13%	4,766,000	-38%	8,136,000	-24%
Jun-25	3,531,000	0%	4,451,000	-49%	7,982,000	-35%
Jul-25	3,950,000	15%	4,334,000	-44%	8,284,000	-26%

Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

It’s not clear where would-be X Android users are going. Rival Bluesky has seen slowing growth in recent months, and its Google Play app pulled in just 119,000 downloads in July. That’s nowhere near the millions that install X on iOS or Android every month. However, Meta’s Threads daily active users have been [catching up to X on mobile devices](#), so, possibly, some Android users could be accounted for there.

In addition to the drop in Google Play installs, X is struggling to grow its subscription revenue, Appfigures found.

In July, X earned \$16.9 million in net revenue, down from the \$18.8 million it earned in March 2025. However, that was a slight tick up from the \$16.8 million it generated in June. (Of course, X still earns the majority of its overall revenue from ads, not in-app premium subscriptions.)

While the declining demand for X on Android is partially to blame for revenue declines, X is also likely losing paying customers to Grok. The latter now has its own [stand-alone app](#) that attracts those who were buying X subscriptions primarily for the AI perks.

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OpenAI launches a sub-\$5 ChatGPT plan in India

Ivan Mehta — 8:57 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

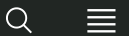
OpenAI today launched a new, cheaper ChatGPT paid subscription plan in India called ChatGPT GO, priced at ₹399 per month (\$4.60), which is more affordable than the ₹1,999 (about \$23) per month Plus Plan.

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— Nick Turley (@nickaturley) [August 19, 2025](#)

“Making ChatGPT more affordable has been a key ask from users! We’re rolling out Go in India first and will learn from feedback before expanding to other countries,” Turley said.

From a currency conversion standpoint, the Plus plan was higher than \$20 for Indian users when offered in local currency. The new Go plan offers a more affordable alternative to people who are looking to use ChatGPT primarily for chat, image generation, and file processing.

Tibor Blaho, a software engineer with a reputation for accurately leaking upcoming AI products, had [previously teased](#) this plan and its details.

While the company is geo-restricting this plan to India, the company said on its [support page](#) that it is working to expand this plan to more regions.



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Last month, Turley noted that ChatGPT now has more than [700 million weekly users](#) worldwide — up from 500 million in March. OpenAI launched its updated image generator feature for ChatGPT in March, [and since then, it has seen an uptick in usage in India](#). OpenAI CEO Sam Altman said in a recent podcast that India is [the company's second biggest market](#). With the Go plan, it wants to cash in on that.

According to app analytics firm AppFigures, India has been the leading country in terms of ChatGPT app downloads across platforms, with over 29 million downloads coming from the country in the last 90 days. However, the app only made \$3.6 million in this period from users in the country.

This move will likely nudge more consumers to subscribe to using ChatGPT more, given its pricing. Other AI companies have also made moves to attract users from the country's internet user base of over 850 million. Last month, Perplexity partnered with network provider Airtel to offer [free Perplexity Pro subscriptions](#). Google also dished up [a free AI Pro plan for India-based students for one year](#).

While OpenAI's move is not giving out any freebies, local and affordable pricing will likely result in a better subscription conversion rate for ChatGPT in India.

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously worked at publications including...

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Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to

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maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”

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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn’t the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn’t really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn’t think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won’t necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I’m seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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